

Of darts and wasps

Wasps have been a feature at the world darts championships at Britain's Alexandra Palace since they began in 2008, often startling players some of whom hope to get stung just for luck.

Suresh Menon

I came to the recent world darts championships via wasps. And not just any wasps, but the so-called Ally Pally wasps. These have been a feature at the championships at Britain's Alexandra Palace since they began in 2008, often startling players some of whom hope to get stung just for luck.

As I write, the tournament is on, prize money is over a million dollars, and the television audience is in the millions too.

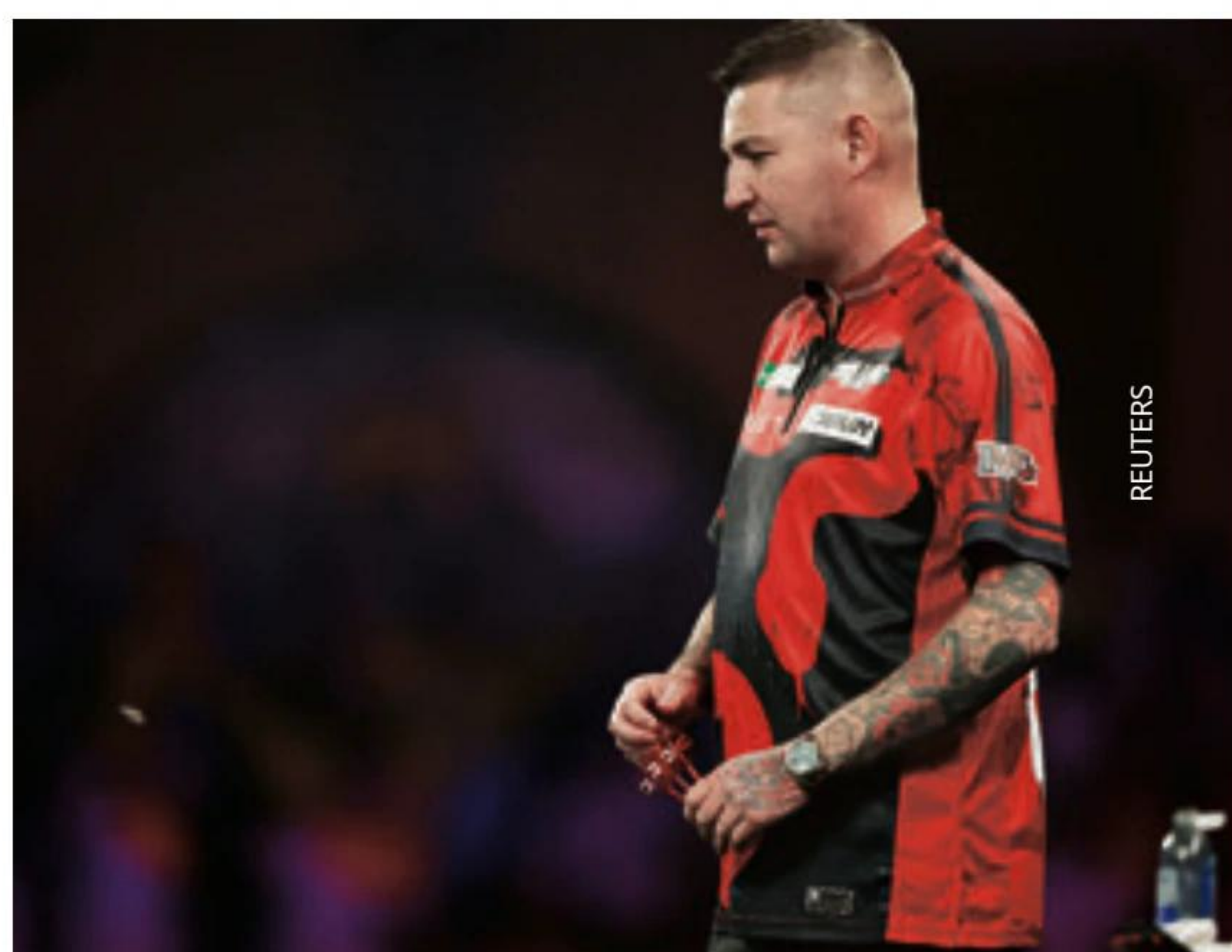
We have all thrown darts at cork boards — for some reason when I was growing up it was seen as a good birthday present for a child. Perhaps because it was cheap and easy to carry.

Darts began as a pastime in the 1300s, with bored soldiers throwing bolts or short arrows at wine barrels, then raised its stature by moving to pubs from where it transitioned into a global sport, with proper rules. George Orwell saw it as the sport of the working class; small pleasures in a changing world.

The beauty of the sport lies in its refusal to pretend. It does not dress itself up as something athletic in the conventional sense. There are no inspirational montages of early morning training runs. The playing arena is usually a friendly pub.

Every dart thrown is a negotiation between confidence and doubt. The player knows exactly where the dart should land. The board is not moving. The distance is fixed. Physics is on your side. And yet, the hand can betray the mind with the tiniest tremor. In that fraction of a second, darts reveals itself as a psychological sport wearing a modest costume.

There is ritual too. The walk-on music, the deliberate pacing, the way players retrieve their darts with the care of someone collecting thoughts after an argument. These routines are not vanity; they are survival. In a sport where margins are measured in millimetres, habit is armour.



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And so to the wasps. In 2012 a player trailing on points who was stung on live TV went on to win the game. It happened again this year to a Kenyan player, a veterinarian by profession.

This year too, the event's sponsors offered odds on the wasp's appearances. They paid out at 16-1 on the wasp to be seen on three or more days of the broadcast.

There is something democratic about darts. You don't need a privileged childhood, elite coaching, or a genetically blessed wingspan. What you need is repetition, obsession, and the ability to ignore a room full of noisy people. This is perhaps why darts players often look like people you might bump into at the grocery store, except with better aim and worse diet.

"The thing about darts," said Sid Waddell, commentator who was known as the voice of the sport "is that it's not like cricket where you can talk to Michael Atherton and ask him to analyse the bloody nuances. Darts does not have nuances. You've got to hurl yourself at it."

As the sport evolves, Waddell might be proved wrong.